Scheme

MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM
MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION March 2026
Fourth SEMESTER
Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG4DSCPSY201 - SELF AND SOCIAL INTERACTIONS
(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 1 hour 30 minutes **Maximum Marks: 50**

Part A: MCQ Answers. Answer all questions. Each carries 1 mark

1. b**.** Mind is inert without consciousness
1. d. Sociology
1. c. Kurt Lewin
1. c. reduced capacity for self regulation due to prior effort
1. c. Cognitive component
1. b. attitudes
1. b. Form a specific plan
1. a. Anchoring effect
1. c. Clarity and correctness
1. d. Reduce dissonance by diffusing accountability
1. c. A social model
1. c. Darley and Latan
1. d. Kin selection theory
1. a. Social learning
1. c. Limits cognitive processing of need

Part B. Short essays answer any 5 7 marks each

Q.16. Evaluate the importance of scientific methods in social psychology. [E]

Scientific methods are fundamental to social psychology because they distinguish it from common sense explanations of human behaviour. Social psychologists study how thoughts, feelings, and actions are influenced by others through systematic observation, measurement, and experimentation, rather than opinion or intuition. Can include methods also

Reasons

1. Empirical validation: Findings are based on data collected through controlled observation, surveys, and experiments rather than mere assumptions.

2. Objectivity and accuracy: Scientific inquiry demands that research be free from personal bias or expectations. Researchers rely on quantifiable evidence and statistical analysis to interpret results.

3. Reliability and replicability: Social behaviours are studied across varied contexts. Replication confirms the stability and generalizability of results.

4. Theory development: Scientific studies help formulate and test theories (e.g., cognitive dissonance theory, attribution theory) that explain and predict behaviour.

5. Ethical balance: The scientific method maintains an ethical boundary—balancing the quest for knowledge and participant rights, such as informed consent and debriefing.

Scientific approaches make social psychology a credible discipline; however, human behaviour is complex and context-bound, so not all variables can be strictly controlled. Despite these limits, scientific methods remain the most reliable route to understanding, predicting, and improving social interaction.

Q17. Explain how personality psychology relates to social psychology. [U]

Personality and social psychology are interrelated fields that examine human behaviour from complementary perspectives.

- Personality psychology focuses on consistent internal traits or dispositions (e.g., extraversion, aggression, empathy) that influence behaviour across situations.
- Social psychology emphasises how external social contexts—the presence and actions of others, norms, culture—shape behaviour and thought.

1. Joint focus on the individual: Both study the individual as a thinking, feeling, acting human being.

2. Interactional view: Social behaviour results from an interaction between internal personality traits and external social forces.

Example: an aggressive personality (personal factor) may lead to violence only under provocation (social factor).

3. Complementary insights: Personality psychology explains *who* behaves aggressively; social psychology explains *when and why* aggression occurs.

4. Overlap in applied areas: Topics such as leadership, persuasion, helping, and prejudice include both personality variables (e.g., empathy, locus of control) and social factors (e.g., norms, group pressure).

Hence, the two areas are distinct but intersect continuously in explaining the whole person within the social environment.

Q18. Examine the effectiveness of fear appeals in persuasion. Under what conditions are they most effective? [A]

Fear appeals are persuasive messages that arouse fear to motivate attitude or behaviour change (e.g., anti-smoking or road-safety campaigns).

Effectiveness:

- Research shows that fear appeals can increase persuasion when they produce moderate fear and when individuals see a clear, achievable way to reduce the threat.

- Strong fear without guidance creates anxiety and leads to defensive avoidance (“It won’t happen to me”).

Most effective when 1. Moderate, not extreme fear.
The message must be alarming enough to draw attention but not paralyzing. 2. Availability of an effective solution. 3. The audience must perceive a recommended action that clearly removes or reduces the danger. 4. Perceived personal susceptibility.
The message should convince people that the threat applies to them, not just others. 5. Credibility of the communicator. Fear appeals from trustworthy experts (doctors, traffic authorities) are more persuasive. 6. Audience characteristics.
Individuals high in self-efficacy respond better; low self-esteem audiences may resist or deny the message.

Fear appeals work best when combined with constructive information (“danger + safety message”)—in essence, arousing fear but also providing hope and control.

Q19. Critically evaluate the adaptive functions of schemas versus their potential for error. Under what conditions do schemas serve us well, and when do they fail us? [E]

Schemas are mental frameworks that organise and interpret social information. They help us process large amounts of data efficiently.

Adaptive functions:

1. Efficiency: Schemas simplify complex realities, allowing quick judgments and decision-making.

2. Predictability: They help anticipate events and other people’s behaviour (e.g., knowing what to expect in a classroom).

3. Memory aid: Schema-consistent information is easier to encode and retrieve.

4. Meaningfulness: They integrate new experiences with existing knowledge.

Potential for error:

1. Stereotyping: Over-generalisation leads to biased judgements about individuals.

2. Resistance to change: Even disconfirming evidence is re-interpreted to fit pre-existing schemas.

3. False memories: People recall schema-consistent but incorrect details.

4. Perceptual distortion: Expectation biases what we notice and encode (selective attention).

Time when schemas serve us well:

- Under time pressure or when rapid interpretation is needed, and the schema is accurate and relevant., 2. In familiar or predictable situations.

When they fail us: 1. In novel, ambiguous, or complex situations where old schemas misfit.

2. When they are rigid or based on prejudice.

Schemas are both adaptive cognitive tools and sources of systematic error. Awareness and flexible updating through experience reduce their biases.

Q20. Compare counterfactual thinking and magical thinking as cognitive errors. [An]

	Counterfactual Thinking	Magical Thinking
Definition	Thinking about *alternative outcomes* to events that have already occurred ("If only I had studied more, I would have passed").	Believing that thoughts or superficial resemblances can influence real-world events without logical cause ("If I wear my lucky charm, I'll succeed").
Cognitive basis	Arises from rational reasoning extended beyond facts; involves mental simulation of "what might have been."	Arises from emotional and associative thinking; violates logical or scientific causation.
Function	Can motivate improvement (upward thinking) or provide comfort (downward thinking).	Offers psychological comfort by creating illusion of control.
Potential error	Produces guilt, regret, or unrealistic beliefs about control over uncontrollable outcomes.	Leads to irrational fear, superstition, avoidance, or false causal links.
Example in daily life	Survivor guilt after accident: "If I had taken a different bus, it wouldn't have happened."	Refusing to eat chocolate shaped like insects; believing it shares the same properties.

Comparison: Both reflect the human tendency to impose order and meaning on events. Counterfactual thinking uses logical structure but misapplies causation to the past; magical thinking breaks rational links altogether. Each shows the limits of human cognition under emotion or uncertainty.

Q21. Define diffusion of responsibility and bystander effect. [K]

A. Diffusion of responsibility: A phenomenon where individuals feel less personal responsibility for taking action when others are present. Responsibility for helping is "diffused" across all bystanders, leading each to assume someone else will act. Here witnesses assume someone else will take charge, and pluralistic ignorance, where people misinterpret the calm demeanor of others as a sign that no crisis exists. Research initiated by Darley and Latané demonstrates that as group size increases, personal accountability diminishes, a pattern that extends beyond physical locations into online environments and workplace hierarchies. However, the sources also highlight that prosocial priming—activating helpful concepts in a person's mind—and clear communication can effectively counteract this apathy. By assigning specific roles and fostering a shared sense of identity, organizations and individuals can bypass social inhibition to promote decisive, life-saving action.

Bystander effect: A social phenomenon where the likelihood of helping decreases as the number of bystanders increases. Discovered by Darley and Latané (1970) after the *Kitty Genovese* case, it occurs through a sequence: failure to notice, misinterpretation, diffusion of responsibility, and evaluating personal risk. Research consistently shows that as the number of bystanders increases, the likelihood of any single person intervening decreases. The concept was famously studied by psychologists John Darley and Bibb Latané In their foundational 1968 experiment, they found that 85% of participants sought help when they believed they were the lone witness to a peer's seizure, but that figure plummeted to 31% when they believed four other bystanders were present.

The effect is primarily driven by three psychological processes: 1. Diffusion of Responsibility: In a group, the sense of personal obligation is diluted because individuals assume someone else will take action. 2. Pluralistic Ignorance: Witnesses often look to the reactions of others to gauge the severity of a situation; if no one else reacts, they may conclude it is not a true emergency. 3. Evaluation Apprehension: Individuals may hesitate to help due to a fear of being judged or appearing foolish to others. The effect can be reduced through 1. Direct Requests: Pointing to a specific person and giving a clear instruction (e.g., "You in the red shirt, call 911") forces that individual to take responsibility. 2. Training: Programs like first-aid training educate people on how to overcome barriers to helping and 3.Prosocial Priming:

Research suggests that activating altruistic concepts in a person's mind before a request can minimize the bystander effect, even in online contexts

Q22. Initiate a discussion on the role of emotional states in prosocial behaviour.

Emotions play a crucial regulatory role in helping behaviour. Prosocial action—helping, sharing, or volunteering—is often guided by how we feel.

1. Positive emotions: Good moods increase empathy and willingness to assist (Cunningham, 1997). Happy individuals interpret situations more positively and see helping as consistent with their mood. But very positive moods may reduce helping if helping interferes with maintaining that pleasant state.

2. Negative emotions: The negative-state relief model (Cialdini et al.) proposes that people help to alleviate their own sadness or guilt. Mild negative feelings increase helping if aiding others can improve mood. Intense emotions like anger or depression, however, often reduce helping because they narrow attention to self.

3. Empathy as emotional driver: 1. Empathy-altruism hypothesis (Batson) suggests that empathic concern—feeling another’s distress—produces true altruistic helping even when escape is possible. 2. When people mirror others’ emotions, empathy and social bonding rise, increasing likelihood of prosocial action.

Prosocial behaviour is most likely when emotional arousal—positive or empathic—is balanced with cognitive awareness of others’ needs. Both “feeling good” and “feeling with” others can turn emotion into compassionate action.